

Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore

I, personally, have always felt the Olympic Village as an all immersive experience. You don't feel the vibes of the Games if you don't live at the Olympic village. For 24x7, it is Olympic level experience. Staying in a hotel or renting out a place does not get you the same experience. People who stay outside miss out on the vibes of the Olympic village. The experience gave me the energy to compete at the highest level.

Walking around the Olympic village, you see so many athletes of different nations, different sports, all in their best shape. The team spirit is very much visible there. It is an amazing mixture of culture as the athletes of the world and others laugh, talk and train together. It is very interesting to talk to some of them, hear their life stories and play friendly matches with them. And when there is a need, the others are ready to support you. With the proximity to so many other venues, on off days, you can watch other athletes in action. I watched boxing, swimming and volleyball.

The Games village has a lot of training facilities. In 2004, I remember watching the 100-metre sprinters practising the exchange of baton. In actual competition, it is done in a flash. But in training, you keep seeing them do it again and again, in pursuit of perfection. I also remember watching Michael Phelps training at the Games village swimming pool.

He was very fast. His coach was pulling him with a rope from the front to help him go faster. I asked the coach why was he not creating the resistance by pulling Phelps from the back. I got an interesting answer. He said that he was trying to get Phelps used to the higher speed and that he was capable of achieving that speed, from a psychological perspective.

The camaraderie at the Games village is fabulous. After dinner,

many jokes are shared. Language and boundaries are no bar. All athletes prepare their best for the Games. Actually, what is more important is how one manages the mind when not competing. One has to be in the best mental shape, yet relaxed. Listening to top athletes and watching them train, we too get into that mode. You feel that your fears are not yours alone. That is something young athletes need to learn.

You learn how to shoot, dribble, pass and run. But nobody teaches you about how to be relaxed. One has to be a student throughout the life, grasping, observing and absorbing the key factors. I remember talking to a world record holder. I was telling him how my heart was pumping as if it would pop out. He said, "you know what, I was feeling the same."

It was very enjoyable to interact with the Indian contingent. I was strolling through the village, and happened to walk into the hall of the Indian hockey team where they had their team meeting. Nobody was around. There was a white board, on which the coach makes a drawing and discusses positions. I wrote a motivational stuff on the board. Later, the hockey players told me that they liked it.

When I went to Athens, my mind was very clear. It was not just for participation. With my background in military, I was determined to win. For about a year and a half, I had remained in the top-3 of the world and was dominant at times. My

preparation was great and despite a relatively bad second round, I managed to make the final. I was fifth in qualification and I could fire my way to the second place. In those days, you may remember that the qualification score counted in the final. Winning the silver medal was a sense of relief and I was happy that I could make the nation proud.

The accolades I received were something I never imagined, that a sport other than cricket could capture the imagination of the entire nation. The love and affection of the people was humbling. It was good for the next generation to start preparing to win. That medal, many felt, broke the glass ceiling.

The others felt, we can do it too. Abhinav Bindra, who won the gold in the next Olympics in Beijing, has also acknowledged this. It gave a sense of belief to everyone.

From one, we got to three medals, and then to six and seven. It is bound to increase.

As a former Sports Minister of the country, and the current Sports Minister of Rajasthan, I feel that we should be talking about the 2036 Olympics. Start preparing for it by grooming the 10 and 12-year-olds. That is the way to continue building on our achievements.

Overall, the amount of resources and support has increased a lot, not just in terms of material, but also in terms of the attention and accolades from the entire country.

As told to Kamesh Srinivasan



When I walked into the hall of the Indian hockey team, there was nobody around. There was a white board, on which the coach makes a drawing and discusses positions. I wrote a motivational stuff on it. Later, the hockey players told me that they liked it.